

GOOD TO THE LAST DROP

By Michael Lieberman and Rebecca Goldstein

Michael Lieberman, of Washington, D.C., is an attorney at Fairmark Partners, an antitrust firm. Rebecca Goldstein, of Albany, Calif., is a research scientist at Merck, developing cancer immunotherapies. While they have many mutual friends and have exchanged messages for years, they met for the first time at a crossword tournament in 2024. Rebecca's favorite part of this puzzle is its theme density. Mike's favorite part is the title. — W.S.

- ACROSS
- 1 Do a little too well?

5 Tops

9 Resident of Ayrshire or Lanarkshire

13 No time at all

19 Discouraged action

20 Mouthy?

21 "What a relief!"

22 Brought (out)

24 Completely destroy with a blast

27 Gaia, by another name

28 Something typically taken every 10 years

29 Doodled

30 Certain bridge positions

32 Segment of a timeline, perhaps

33 The moon's "maria"

36 Circa

38 "Rhoda" actress Valerie

40 Version of a textbook designed for instruction

44 Salon substance

45 Muppet who loves pigeons

46 "My life is over"

47 Sharpness

48 Sarcastic response to a show-off

52 Walked gingerly

53 Product with Pro, Air and Mini varieties

55 Conical shelter

57 Use salt instead of sugar while baking, say

58 Skewered Indonesian dish

60 ___ Winter, basketball coach who famously innovated the "triangle offense"

61 Had a brain fart

66 Top-left PC key

69 Like some simple repair jobs, in brief

70 Grilled South American fare

72 Smoothed (out)

73 "Things are only going to get worse" ... or a hint to answering the seven italicized clues in this puzzle

78 Science-and-nature magazine, familiarly

79 Muckety-muck

80 Frequently, poetically
- 81 Fair-hiring inits.

82 Chemical element whose use led to the first known law against poisoning

84 Herman ___ (potato chip entrepreneur)

85 More sardonic

87 Rest area?

90 Speeds of slow-moving traffic

92 "It's ___ real"

93 Delicate, as beauty

96 Photo-editing technique used to create a smooth transition

100 Wear (out)

102 Middle-of-the-night woe

104 Duchess of ___ (noted Spanish title)

105 Made younger-looking in an editing studio, say

107 Reality TV franchise created by Tyra Banks

108 Philosophy symbolized by yin and yang

111 Ruby lookalike

112 Throw, in modern slang

113 Fort Collins sch.

114 Calls to task?

116 Company behind the machine used to make Slurpees

118 Kind of paper in a lab

123 In back

125 "Wait, are we done?"

129 Queen of the fairies

130 Dueling weapon

131 Skin softener

132 Fruit also known as a "uniq"

133 Largest bird in North America

134 X-ray units

135 Immodest

136 "You can't make me!," e.g.
- DOWN
- 1 "The Exchange" ailer

2 Flaw in an argument

3 Unknown author, for short

4 Squabbles

5 Unresolved parts of a plot

6 Org. to which you might provide your bank account info

7 Renewable energy structure

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- 8 Lost traction

9 Globelike shape

10 Dress down

11 Poetic contraction

12 Many middle schoolers

13 Ones pressed for cash?

14 Top of a latte

15 Mucho

16 M.L.B. team that once went by OAK on scoreboards

17 In hot water?

18 Fashion designer Carolina

23 Shortage

25 Behind

26 Certain public transit network

31 Singer whose "Hello" was the fastest video ever to reach 1 billion views on YouTube

34 "People ___ Strange" (the Doors song)

35 Conduct inciting an insurrection

37 World's first billion-dollar corporation

39 Sac fly result

40 Game piece in Rummikub

41 Royal title

42 Where jet-setters may rub elbows

43 Chalice

49 P.D. alert
- 50 Prefix meaning "sun"

51 "Heavens to Betsy!"

54 Subscription-only website feature

56 Look into

59 Contribute

60 Chicago paper, informally

62 N.Y.C. neighborhood that's home to the Grey Art Museum

63 Lower-body exercise

64 Occupational suffix

65 J.F.K. predecessor

67 Aromatic herb

68 Hold tightly

70 Mariner's greeting

71 Natural attraction

73 Two peas ___ pod

74 Pitch

75 French wine region

76 LeBron James or Nikola Jokic

77 Delivery person's assignment: Abbr.

83 "Wheels"

85 Beverage infused with THC

86 Fixed, as a "m-i-t-s-a-k-e"

88 County in western New York
- 89 Deck out?

91 Shoe with a thick sole

92 Part of an equestrian's ensemble

94 Small songbird

95 Benefit plan option, in brief

96 Wealthy sort

97 Stretchy

98 "Next on my list"

99 ___ chi

101 Lit up, in a way

103 ___ Valley (San Francisco neighborhood)

106 Less challenging

109 Shell out

110 Video game character aptly celebrated on Mar. 10

115 Bicyclist's setting

117 Latin list ender

119 Lead-in to a conclusion

120 ___ Millions (multistate lottery)

121 Some addresses

122 Dos + cuatro

124 China's largest ethnic group

126 Wellness resort offering

127 Horn contents at a Viking feast

128 Depressed

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